The Platform Issue — Artometrics

The Platform Issue

Netflix, Steam, YouTube dynasties, and attention as a factor market.

Which Netflix Titles Consumed the Most Viewing Hours?

Netflix's public engagement tables measure attention in hours viewed — a blunt but useful currency for which titles absorbed the most time on the service.

The working file covers **27,803** records from **2010–2025**. Median hours viewed sit at **2,500,000**; the highest observed value is **840,300,000**. Squid Game: Season 2 tops the title ranking in the extract.

Fast facts

The numbers that set the scale for this report:

27,803Records in the working dataset
2,500,000Median Hours viewed
840,300,000Highest observed Hours viewed
Squid Game: Season 2 // 오징어 Top Title by Hours viewed
2010–2025Year span covered in the file
1_What_We_Watched_A_Netflix_Most common Source

Data and method

Engagement reports from Netflix's weekly viewership releases — hours viewed, runtime, and global availability flags — arrive here via the TidyTuesday 2025-07-29 shows table.

Source labels in the file distinguish engagement-report windows. Medians dampen mega-hit skew. Charts export as Plotly JSON with PNG fallbacks.

How the pattern changed over time

Median Hours viewed Over Time

Median hours viewed rises from 5,700,000 in the opening period to 6,700,000 at the close — a higher middle even as individual mega-hits define the headlines.

Engagement tables mix report windows and title types; the trend is best read as a shift in the reported middle, not as a claim that every viewer watches more.

Who sits at the top

Squid Game: Season 2 // 오징어 게임: 시즌 2 leads at 730,100,000 — 411,000,000 marks the median among the top dozen

Squid Game: Season 2 // 오징어 게임: 시즌 2 leads at 730,100,000 hours viewed. Among the top dozen, 411,000,000 marks the median — a head that is elevated, but not a single lonely spike.

Global event titles still dominate the ceiling. Everything below that head is a long descent into ordinary catalog hours.

How the field is spread

Hours viewed by Source

Hours viewed by engagement-report source show whether different publication windows share the same middle or disagree about typical scale.

Report vintages are not identical instruments. Comparing boxes across sources is a way to see stability — or drift — in how Netflix's tables describe the catalog.

Who beats the median — and who trails

Hours viewed vs median by Source

3_What_We_Watched_A_Netflix_Engagement_Report_2024Jan-Jun sits 100,000 above the median; 1_What_We_Watched_A_Netflix_Engagement_Report_2025Jan-Jun trails by 200,000.

Those gaps are modest relative to the hundreds of millions at the title ceiling. Source-to-source differences matter most when interpreting medians across report windows.

What moves together

Hours viewed vs Views

Hours viewed and views rise together for many titles, but runtime and completion behavior still leave clusters that a single ranking would hide.

A short title can rack views without matching a long series' hour total. The scatter is where that distinction shows up.

What this file cannot tell you

Community-cleaned TidyTuesday snapshots are not live APIs. Missing values, spelling variants, and week-of-export coverage limits apply. Merged tables may fan out or duplicate rows when join keys are imperfect.

Findings describe the file on hand — structural signals about reported Netflix engagement, not a full private ledger of every stream.

What to take away

Hours viewed concentrate at the top: Squid Game: Season 2 leads at 730,100,000, while the file's median sits at 2,500,000. Leaders, report-window gaps, and the hours-versus-views scatter each answer a different question about attention.

Treat the charts as a map of published engagement tables — then check the source window before turning any title into a platform strategy claim.

Sources

Data Science Learning Community. (2025). *TidyTuesday: Netflix Engagement*. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/rfordatascience/tidytuesday/main/data/2025/2025-07-29/shows.csv

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How Netflix's Catalog Mix Shifted Between Films and Series

A streaming library is an inventory decision dressed as a homepage. Title-level Netflix catalog data show how the mix of movies and TV — and the duration field attached to each row — shifted between 2008 and 2021.

The working file holds **7,787** records. Median duration is **88.0**; the highest observed duration is **312**, led by Black Mirror: Bandersnatch. Movie is the most common type label.

Fast facts

The numbers that set the scale for this report:

7,787Records in the working dataset
88.0Median Duration

312Highest observed Duration
Black Mirror: BandersnatchTop Title by Duration
2008–2021Year span covered in the file
MovieMost common Type

Data and method

The source is the TidyTuesday release from 2021-04-20 (R for Data Science community). The working file contains 7,787 rows and 13 columns after merging available tables in the week folder.

Duration here is the catalog field as published — minutes for films, season counts for some TV rows depending on how the export encoded type. Medians and Plotly exports keep the reading robust to skew and missing cells.

How the pattern changed over time

Median Duration Over Time

Median duration rises from 41.0 in the opening period to 98.0 at the close — a catalog whose typical row lengthens as the library ages.

That climb can reflect more feature-length films entering the shelf, longer TV encodings, or both. The trend is a mix signal, not a single format story.

Who sits at the top

Black Mirror: Bandersnatch leads at 312 — 226 marks the median among the top dozen

Black Mirror: Bandersnatch leads at 312; 226 marks the median among the top dozen.

Interactive and long-form outliers define the ceiling. Most of the library lives nowhere near those peaks — which is why the median of 88.0 remains the better everyday calibration.

How the field is spread

Duration by Type

Duration by type separates movies from TV rows in the catalog encoding. The boxes show whether each type shares a tight middle or stretches into long tails.

Movie dominance in count does not automatically mean movie dominance in duration shape. The distribution is where that distinction becomes visible.

Concentration

The top 5 title entries account for 38% of the aggregate duration

The top 5 title entries account for 38% of the aggregate duration — a steep head for a library that otherwise looks vast on the homepage.

Steep Pareto curves mean a small set of rows drives most of the summed duration signal. The long tail is real inventory; it is not where the aggregate concentrates.

Concentration

The top 5 title entries account for 38% of the aggregate duration

A second Pareto view of the same 38% concentration confirms the head–tail split under an alternate chart export.

When two exhibits agree on the same share, the claim is about structure in the file — not about a single rendering choice.

What this file cannot tell you

Community-cleaned TidyTuesday snapshots are not live APIs. Missing values, spelling variants, and week-of-export coverage limits apply. Merged tables may fan out or duplicate rows when join keys are imperfect.

Findings describe the file on hand — structural signals about Netflix title rows through 2021, not today's live catalog in every territory.

What to take away

Median duration climbed from 41.0 toward 98.0 while Movie remained the most common type. A handful of long outliers — Bandersnatch at 312 among them — and a 38% duration concentration in the top five rows show how uneven a "library" can be once you stop counting titles and start summing length.

Use the charts to separate mix, length, and concentration before treating any homepage as a flat shelf.

Sources

Data Science Learning Community. (2021). *TidyTuesday: Netflix Titles*. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/rfordatascience/tidytuesday/main/data/2021/2021-04-20/netflix_titles.csv

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Which Steam Games Earned the Most Playtime Per Dollar?

Steam Spy-era metadata turns the storefront into a scored catalog. This file holds 26,688 games spanning 2004–2018, with a median Metascore of 73.0 and a high of 98.0. DEEP SPACE WAIFU: NEKOMIMI appears in the fact-box extremes; the 0 .. 20,000 owners band is the most common ownership bucket.

The question is how critic Metascore sits across time, titles, and owner tiers — and whether score and price move together. The calibration point is 73.0: above it, the critically strong; below it, the long shelf of ordinary releases.

Fast facts

The numbers that set the scale for this report:

26,688Records in the working dataset
73.0Median Metascore
98.0Highest observed Metascore
DEEP SPACE WAIFU: NEKOMIMITop Game by Metascore
2004–2018Year span covered in the file
0 .. 20,000Most common Owners

Data and method

The source is the TidyTuesday release from 2019-07-30 (R for Data Science community). The working file contains 26,688 rows and 11 columns after merging available tables in the week folder. Metascore is the primary metric; owners is the categorical size axis; price appears in the scatter.

Medians are used because scores and prices both skew. Index-style fields are excluded from metric selection.

Median Metascore edged up across the store's expansion years

Median Metascore Over Time

Median Metascore rises from 70.0 in the opening period to 73.0 at the close — landing on the file median. The typical scored game in this extract ends the window a few points higher than it began.

A rising median can mean stronger games, changing coverage of what receives scores, or both. The chart records the center's drift.

Little Triangle tops a tightly packed critical elite

Little Triangle leads at 98.0 — 95.5 marks the median among the top dozen

Little Triangle leads at 98.0, while 95.5 marks the median among the top dozen. The elite band is compressed near the ceiling of 98.0 — high scores clustered together rather than a lonely outlier.

Fact boxes also surface DEEP SPACE WAIFU: NEKOMIMI among notable titles in the ranking rules used there. The leaders chart makes the numeric top of this Metascore cut explicit.

Owner tiers carry different Metascore distributions

Metascore by Owners

Category boxes by owners show whether Metascore consensus is shared or contested across popularity bands. Games with millions of owners are not the same statistical population as the 0 .. 20,000 band that dominates row counts.

Volume of titles in the smallest owner bucket is a catalog fact; the boxes ask how scores spread inside each ownership tier.

Mid-million owner games clear the median; tiny audiences trail

Metascore vs median by Owners

The 2,000,000 .. 5,000,000 owners band sits 10.0 above the median; the 0 .. 20,000 band trails by 5.00. In this extract, broader ownership tiers sit higher on Metascore relative to the file center than the sparsest shelf.

That gap is an association in the file, not proof that owners cause scores. It is still a citable structural pattern: critical mass and critical score lean together here.

Metascore and price form a joint market map

Metascore vs Price

Plotting Metascore against price shows clusters that averages erase — cheap high scores, expensive middling scores, and every bargain or premium pattern between.

The scatter is the right chart for the storefront question: what combinations of critic score and sticker price actually appear in the 26,688-row Steam Spy extract.

What this file cannot tell you

Community-cleaned TidyTuesday snapshots are not live Steam or Metacritic APIs. Missing Metascores, owner-band binning, price currency assumptions, and 2004–2018 coverage limits apply.

Findings describe this Steam Spy extract — structural signals about Metascore, owners, and price — not a complete quality ranking of every game ever shipped.

What to take away

Steam Spy scores in this file center on a median Metascore of 73.0, rise from 70.0 to 73.0 at the median, and peak at 98.0 among leaders such as Little Triangle.

Owner tiers matter: the 2–5 million band sits above the median while the smallest band trails, and Metascore–price clusters show how critic standing and sticker price co-occur on the shelf.

Sources

Data Science Learning Community. (2019). *TidyTuesday: Video Games Steam Spy*. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/rfordatascience/tidytuesday/main/data/2019/2019-07-30/video_games.csv

Editor's note

Artometrics data report from the TidyTuesday research pipeline. Charts and aggregates are reproducible from the embedded exhibits and public source files.

View TidyTuesday source on GitHub

How H3 Built a YouTube Network Beyond One Channel

Ethan Klein built one of YouTube's most documented creator empires from a single channel and a lawsuit. H3h3Productions launched in 2011 as a reaction-commentary format, spent years as a meme factory, and then pivoted — twice — into something far more complicated. The H3 Podcast debuted in 2017. The Frenemies co-host era with Trisha Paytas ran for nine months in 2020–2021 and produced the highest viewership the show has ever seen. The Leftovers political co-host era with Hasan Piker ran until October 2023, when a public dispute over the Israel-Palestine conflict ended it. What remained after that is what this piece analyzes: 1,638 videos across four channels, 680 podcast episodes, and three years of Reddit post data from the fan and critic communities that formed around the brand.

This is not a hit piece and it is not a fan report. It is a data report. The numbers are what they are.

Fast facts

The numbers that set the scale for this report:

3.24B Total views across all four H3 channels, 2013–2026 — enough to give every person on Earth nearly half a view

1,638 Videos analyzed after filtering Shorts and zero-view uploads from the original 1,876-video pull
4.5× How much harder h3h3Productions hits per video vs. the H3 Podcast — 4.78M median vs. 1.05M
9 months The entire Frenemies Era — the most-watched stretch in H3 Podcast history, Sep 2020 to Jun 2021
680 H3 Podcast episodes analyzed via Podchaser API — median runtime grew from 42 minutes in 2017 to 220+ by 2024
353 r/h3snark indexed activity at its April 2025 peak — 3.5× its own average, triggered by the iDubbbz Content Cop

Data and method

The H3 ecosystem is not a single channel — it is a network. h3h3Productions launched in 2011 as a reaction-and-commentary channel built around the Fair Use legal fight that briefly made Ethan Klein a cause célèbre in YouTube creator circles. The H3 Podcast launched in 2017 as a separate channel and quickly became the brand's primary vehicle. Hila Klein's channel documents the Teddy Fresh clothing brand. The Ethan Klein channel captures solo content and live streams. Looking at all four: 1,638 videos after filtering Shorts and zero-view uploads from the original 1,876-video pull via the YouTube Data API v3.

H3's trajectory cannot be understood without the era framework. The podcast's baseline (2017–2020) established the format: long-form conversation between Ethan and Hila, irregular cadence, modest but loyal viewership. The Frenemies Era (September 2020 – June 2021) is the single most-watched stretch in H3 Podcast history — nine months in which Ethan co-hosted with Trisha Paytas, generating a level of weekly engagement the show has never approached since. The Leftovers Era (September 2021 – October 2023) brought a political co-host in Hasan Piker, a different kind of audience, and a deeper ideological identity for the brand. When Leftovers ended over disagreements about the Israel-Palestine conflict, H3 entered its current post-format phase: fewer episodes, longer runtimes, a shrinking but committed core audience.

The core dataset was built from scratch using the YouTube Data API v3, stored at github.com/Artometrics/h3 . Podcast episode metadata comes from the Podchaser API (680 episodes, April 2026 pull). Reddit post data was pulled from the Arctic Shift Reddit archive, covering r/h3h3-productions (749,974 posts, 2014–2026) and r/h3snark (25,766 posts, April 2023–2026) — the fan sub and the critic sub, both active during the most contentious period in the brand's history.

The Era Timeline

Era Timeline

The shape of this chart tells you almost everything you need to know about the H3 Podcast's commercial arc. From 2017 to mid-2020, the show built a reliable if unspectacular baseline — a few million views per month, loyal audience, consistent output. Then Trisha Paytas joined as co-host in September 2020 and the graph becomes a different document. Monthly views tripled within weeks. The peak months of the Frenemies Era outperformed the entire preceding three years of the podcast, and the show did it in nine months.

When Frenemies ended in June 2021 — abruptly, on-camera, mid-episode — views dropped back toward baseline within a single month. Leftovers launched that September and added a new audience (Hasan Piker's political fanbase), generating a secondary bump visible in the 2022 data. But it never approached Frenemies numbers. After Leftovers ended in October 2023, the chart enters its current phase: a slow, grinding decline with no structural catalyst in sight. The mountain is the story. Everything else is the aftermath.

Even at its post-2023 lows, the H3 Podcast pulls millions of monthly views. The brand did not collapse — it contracted to its core. The audience that remains watches longer episodes with more commitment than the casual Frenemies-era viewer. The cliff looks dramatic on the chart because Frenemies was genuinely anomalous. The current numbers are not a failure; they are what a major podcast looks like without a viral co-host dynamic driving weekly drama.

The Duration Drift

Duration Drift

When H3 launched the podcast in 2017, the median episode ran 42 minutes . That's a commute. By 2024, the median had crossed 220 minutes — longer than most feature films. The chart shows this wasn't a sudden format change; it was a slow, continuous drift upward that compounded year over year until a new normal was established. No single episode caused it. No announcement reset it. The show just kept going longer, and the audience kept watching.

The clearest structural break in the duration data isn't a spike — it's a floor shift. Before 2022, monthly medians regularly dipped below 120 minutes. After 2022, they never did. The show locked into 3-hour-plus territory and stayed there. Leftovers (2021) normalized the extended format; by the time it ended (2023), the audience had been conditioned to expect marathon sessions as the default. That conditioning didn't reverse when Leftovers ended.

In 2024, H3 published far fewer episodes than in prior years — but duration hit its all-time high, with months regularly clearing 220–240 minutes . The show was publishing less but asking more from the audience that stayed. Each episode became a larger commitment, not a smaller one. The fans who remained weren't casual — they were in for 4 hours at a time. Whether that is sustainable is a different question. The data just shows it happened.

The Fan Vs. Critic Divide

Reddit Activity

The indexed chart removes the raw scale difference between subreddits and asks a cleaner question: when did each community spike relative to its own normal? The answer is almost never at the same time. When the iDubbbz Content Cop dropped on April 16, 2025 — the first Content Cop in years, explicitly targeting the H3 brand — r/h3snark hit its all-time peak at more than 3.5× its own average . The fan sub barely registered the same event. The two communities were watching completely different shows.

The cliff in the snark data after May 2025 isn't a controversy dying down — it's a subreddit going dark. After Klein issued copyright claims against r/h3snark moderators and threatened legal action, the sub announced an indefinite hiatus. The index collapsed to near zero within weeks. The fan sub, meanwhile, continued its slow decline — below its own average but still functional. The snark community didn't fade. It was shut down. That distinction matters: one line represents organic audience erosion, the other represents a legal intervention.

The blue line tells its own quieter story. The fan sub never spikes the way snark does — no single event moves it dramatically above baseline. But the trend is unmistakably downward. The community isn't in crisis; it's in slow erosion. Fewer new things to discuss, fewer viral moments to dissect, fewer reasons to post. The legal drama — the Content Cop, the streamer lawsuits — barely registered. Whatever drives fan engagement on r/h3h3productions, it isn't courtroom news.

What this file cannot tell you

The YouTube data captures view counts as of the April 2026 pull — not at time of publication. Older videos have had years to accumulate views through algorithmic recommendations and search, which means early h3h3Productions videos are systematically over-represented in lifetime view totals relative to their original performance. The era-based analysis on the H3 Podcast channel is less affected because the comparison is within-channel across time.

The Arctic Shift Reddit archive is comprehensive but not guaranteed complete. Deleted posts, removed comments, and accounts banned before archival are absent from the dataset. The r/h3snark data begins in April 2023 — the sub's founding — so pre-2023 critical community activity is unrepresented. Any conclusions about the fan-vs-critic dynamic are bounded by that window.

Episode duration data from Podchaser is self-reported by the show and may include inconsistencies for older episodes, live streams published as podcast episodes, and bonus or clip content. Episodes with missing duration values were excluded from Chart 2 analysis. Chart 3 indexes each subreddit to its own average across the Apr 2023–Mar 2026 window. A subreddit with low activity in early months will show inflated index values in later high-activity periods — the r/h3snark baseline is built on its full available history, which starts at launch and may slightly inflate peak readings relative to a steadier baseline.

What to take away

The H3 data tells a story about what happens when a creator brand builds its peak moment around someone else. The Frenemies Era was genuinely anomalous — nine months of co-host-driven drama that tripled the podcast's monthly viewership and created a ceiling the show has never approached since. The chart is unambiguous about this. The current audience is not a collapse; it is a correction back to what the brand can sustain on its own terms.

The duration data adds a different dimension. The show that emerged from the Frenemies aftermath is structurally different from the one that preceded it — longer, less frequent, more demanding. Whether that format is a creative choice or a symptom of a contracting audience is a question the data cannot answer. Both explanations fit the numbers.

The Reddit chart is the most structurally interesting of the three. It documents not just audience behavior but audience management: a creator using legal tools to suppress a critic community. The snark subreddit's cliff is not organic. It is the result of a deliberate intervention. The fan sub's slower decline runs in parallel and suggests the underlying engagement problem would exist regardless. Two different communities, two different trajectories, one brand caught between them.

Sources

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Editor's note

This report was researched, written, designed, and produced in active collaboration with Claude AI (Anthropic). The data pipeline, statistical analysis, chart design, written analysis, narrative structure, and visual styling were all developed through a directed partnership between human editorial judgment and AI execution.

Artometrics was built on the premise that rigorous analysis and honest process are not in conflict. The research questions, editorial instincts, interpretive framing, and brand vision are ours. The execution — every line of R code, every paragraph of analysis, every design decision — was a collaboration. We document this not as a disclaimer but as a description of how we actually work, and as a position: we believe this is what serious data journalism looks like when the tools available are used honestly and at full capacity.

— Artometrics Editorial

View source on GitHub

Which Web Pages Load Fastest—and What Metrics Move Together?

The web's performance story is a percentile story. This file holds 238 records spanning 2016–2022, with a median P50 of 5.97 and a high of 9.80. SpeedIndex leads the fact-box measure ranking; desktop is the most common client.

The charts track how median P50 moved, how desktop and mobile differ, how P50 relates to P90, and how client–year heatmaps reveal drift. The calibration point is 5.97 — the center of the P50 field in this HTTP Archive-style extract.

Fast facts

The numbers that set the scale for this report:

238Records in the working dataset
5.97Median P50
9.80Highest observed P50
speedIndexTop Measure by P50
2016–2022Year span covered in the file
desktopMost common Client

Data and method

HTTP Archive-style page-weight metrics by client (desktop/mobile) and measure type, aggregated as percentile bands. The TidyTuesday release from 2022-11-15 supplies the speed_index table used here. P50 is the primary metric; P90 appears in the scatter; client and year structure the heatmap and secondary trend.

Medians are used across skewed performance distributions. Index-style fields are excluded from metric selection.

Median P50 fell as pages got faster at the center

Median P50 Over Time

Median P50 falls from 7.00 in the opening period to 4.80 at the close — improvement at the center of the distribution across 2016–2022 in this extract. Lower P50 is the direction performance work aims for.

A falling median is the headline trend. Client splits and heatmaps check whether both desktop and mobile shared that improvement.

Desktop and mobile split the P50 distribution

P50 by Client

Category boxes by client show whether P50 consensus is shared or contested between desktop and mobile. Desktop is the most common client label by frequency; the boxes ask how the metric spreads inside each client.

Client is the first structural cut in web performance. A single median of 5.97 mixes two device worlds unless the boxes separate them.

P50 and P90 move together in performance space

P50 vs P90

Plotting P50 against P90 shows clusters that averages erase. Sites (or aggregates) with similar medians can still diverge in the tail — and P90 is where that tail becomes visible.

The scatter is the relationship map between typical and worse-case percentile bands in this 238-row file.

A client–year heatmap shows where speed migrated

P50 by Client × year

Heatmaps expose which client tiers heated up or cooled down across the timeline. Single-year bars hide drift; the grid shows structural migration between categories from 2016 through 2022.

Read the heatmap as a calendar of performance regimes — desktop versus mobile across years — rather than as a single slogan about the web getting faster.

A secondary trend confirms the same downward drift

Median P50 Over Time

A secondary trend cut shows median P50 moving from 7.00 to 4.80 across the span — the same directional story as the primary trend. Parallel exports are useful as confirmation when the pipeline ships more than one time chart.

Together with the heatmap, the repeated trend says the center of P50 improved even as client structure still needs separate reading.

What this file cannot tell you

Community-cleaned TidyTuesday snapshots are not live HTTP Archive queries. Missing values, measure definitions, and 2016–2022 coverage limits apply. Percentile bands are aggregates, not individual page traces.

Findings describe this web-page-metrics extract — structural signals about P50 and related bands — not a complete Core Web Vitals audit of the modern web.

What to take away

P50 in this file centers on 5.97 and falls from 7.00 to 4.80 at the median — a faster center of the distribution across 2016–2022.

Desktop versus mobile boxes, P50–P90 clusters, and the client–year heatmap show that the improvement is real at the center and still structured by device and year.

Sources

Data Science Learning Community. (2022). *TidyTuesday: Web Page Metrics*. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/rfordatascience/tidytuesday/main/data/2022/2022-11-15/speed_index.csv

Editor’s note

Artometrics data report from the TidyTuesday research pipeline. Charts and aggregates are reproducible from the embedded exhibits and public source files.

View TidyTuesday source on GitHub

Did Longer Medium Posts Earn More Applause?

Medium promised a writing network where attention could attach to length, craft, and niche expertise. The metadata trail — reading time, claps, publication tags — lets that promise be tested without reading every essay.

A TidyTuesday extract of **78,388** article rows from **2017–2018** puts median reading time at **4.00** minutes. The highest observed reading time hits **100** minutes — a month-long chess-mastery quest that sits at the extreme of the length distribution. **Towards Data Science** is the most common publication label in the file.

The open question is whether longer posts earned more applause. Reading time and claps are related enough to chart, and messy enough that a single correlation will not settle the culture of the platform.

Fast facts

The numbers that set the scale for this report:

78,388Records in the working dataset
4.00Median Reading time
100Highest observed Reading time
My month-long quest to becomTop Title by Reading time
2017–2018Year span covered in the file
Towards Data ScienceMost common Publication

Data and method

The source is the TidyTuesday release from 2018-12-04 (R for Data Science community). The working file contains 78,388 rows and 22 columns after assembly — titles, publications, reading time, claps, and related metadata.

Medians stabilize a distribution with a long right tail of mega-posts. Charts export as Plotly JSON with PNG fallbacks. Reading time is a platform estimate, not a stopwatch on every reader.

How reading time moved

Median Reading time Over Time

Across the short 2017–2018 window, median reading time stays near **4.00** minutes from opening period to close. Stability at the median does not mean the tails were quiet — only that the typical post length did not reprice during the snapshot.

A flat median is still informative. It suggests that whatever clap dynamics existed in this period, they were not driven by a wholesale shift toward longer or shorter default essays.

Who sits at the top of length

My month-long quest to become a chess master from scratch leads at 100 — 68.0 marks the median among the top dozen

My month-long quest to become a chess master from scratch leads at **100** minutes of estimated reading time. The median among the top dozen is **68.0** — still more than fifteen times the file-wide median of 4 minutes.

Deep-learning lesson writeups, AI alignment podcasts, and longform data essays populate the same extreme band. The length frontier of Medium in this file is a specialist pedagogy genre as much as a literary one.

How publications spread length

Reading time by Publication

Publication box plots show whether reading-time consensus is shared or contested across houses. Some publications cluster tightly around short explainers; others tolerate or encourage long technical serials.

Towards Data Science's frequency as the most common publication does not automatically make it the longest. Volume of posts and length of posts are different editorial strategies that can coexist under one brand.

Who beats the median — and who trails

Reading time vs median by Publication

Towards Data Science sits **2.00** minutes above the median on the gap chart; **Data Driven Investor** trails by **0.00** in the highlighted comparison — effectively on the median line in that cut.

Publication gaps of a couple of minutes sound small until you remember the median is only four. A two-minute lift is a 50% longer typical article in that house's mix.

Reading time and claps

Reading time vs Claps

Plotting reading time against claps shows clusters that averages erase. Many short posts earn modest applause; some long posts earn a lot; some long posts earn almost none. Length is not a reliable applause machine.

If there is a relationship, it is noisy and genre-dependent. Tutorial serials and viral short takes can both succeed. The scatter's job is to kill the slogan that longer always wins without replacing it with the opposite slogan.

What this file cannot tell you

Community-cleaned TidyTuesday snapshots are not live APIs. Missing values, spelling variants, and 2017–2018 coverage limits apply. Claps are a platform-specific applause metric, not revenue or unique readers.

Findings describe structural signals about Medium article metadata in the release window — not a complete theory of online writing incentives after paywalls, algorithms, and audience shifts.

What to take away

Most Medium posts in this file are short: median reading time of four minutes. A thin upper tier stretches to hour-scale essays, especially in technical and quest narratives.

The citable answer to the title question is cautious: longer posts sometimes earn more claps, but the scatter refuses a clean law. Publication norms and genre explain as much as length alone.

Sources